



SMART INDIA HACKATHON 2026

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A deployable AI-powered autonomous drone that aids search-and-rescue operations by detecting people and hazards, thereby improving responder safety and reducing victim discovery time.

PROBLEM STATEMENT ID
26177

PS CATEGORY
Hardware

TEAM NAME
Drone Syndicate

THEME
Robotics and Drones

ORGANISATION
Qualcomm Inc

TEAM ID

5.8 h

to sweep the 15 km² Wayanad footprint,
against 5+ days for 1,300 responders

+64

survivors per 100 trapped, from reaching
them inside the six-hour window

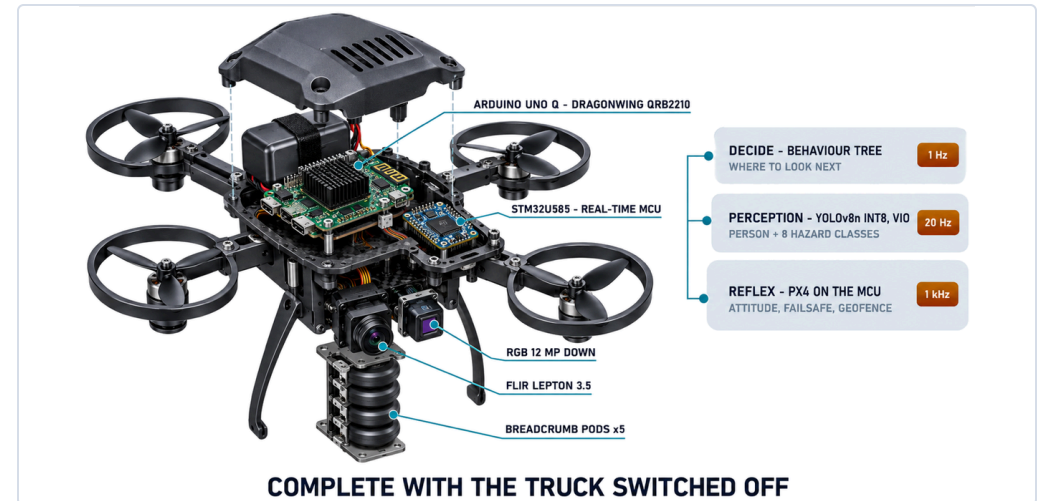
₹502

per km² surveyed — 27× cheaper than a
charter helicopter

SIX SCOUTS, ONE TRUCK — 15 KM² IN 5.8 HOURS

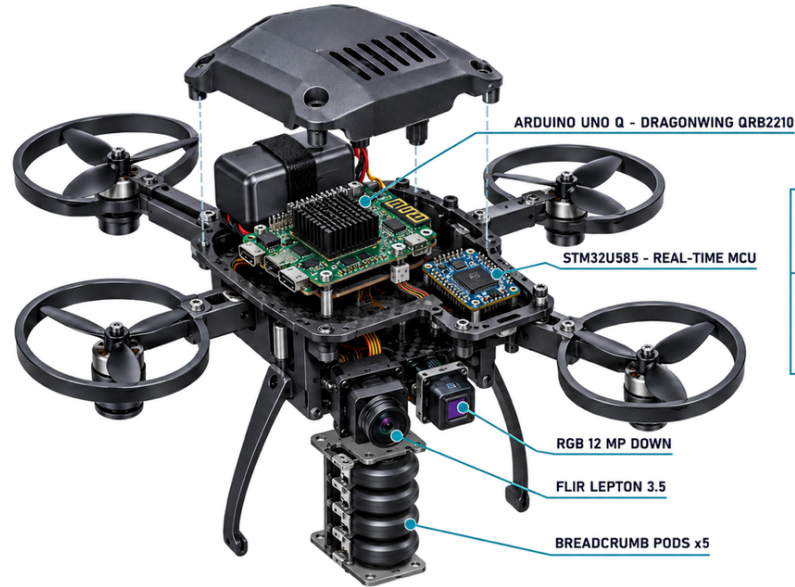


ONE SCOUT — COMPLETE WITH THE TRUCK SWITCHED OFF



One scout is a complete answer to the problem statement. Six is the answer to Wayanad.

① ONE AIRCRAFT — COMPLETE WITH THE TRUCK SWITCHED OFF



COMPLETE WITH THE TRUCK SWITCHED OFF

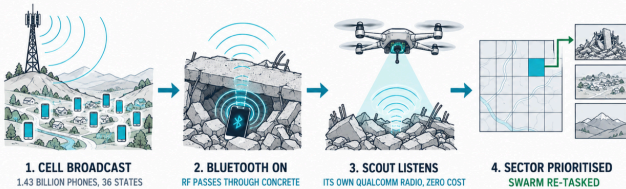
- DECIDE - BEHAVIOUR TREE
WHERE TO LOOK NEXT 1 Hz
- PERCEPTION - YOLOv8n INT8, VIO
PERSON + 8 HAZARD CLASSES 20 Hz
- REFLEX - PX4 ON THE MCU
ATTITUDE, FAILSAFE, GEOFENCE 1 kHz

② SIX OF THEM — 15 KM² SWEEP IN 5.8 HOURS



③ THE IDEA NOBODY HAS USED

SACHET-TODAY - EVACUATE
SACHET AS A SENSOR - BE DETECTABLE



C-DOT Cell Broadcast Solution, run by NDMA as SACHET

PROPOSED SOLUTION — REQUIRED POINTERS

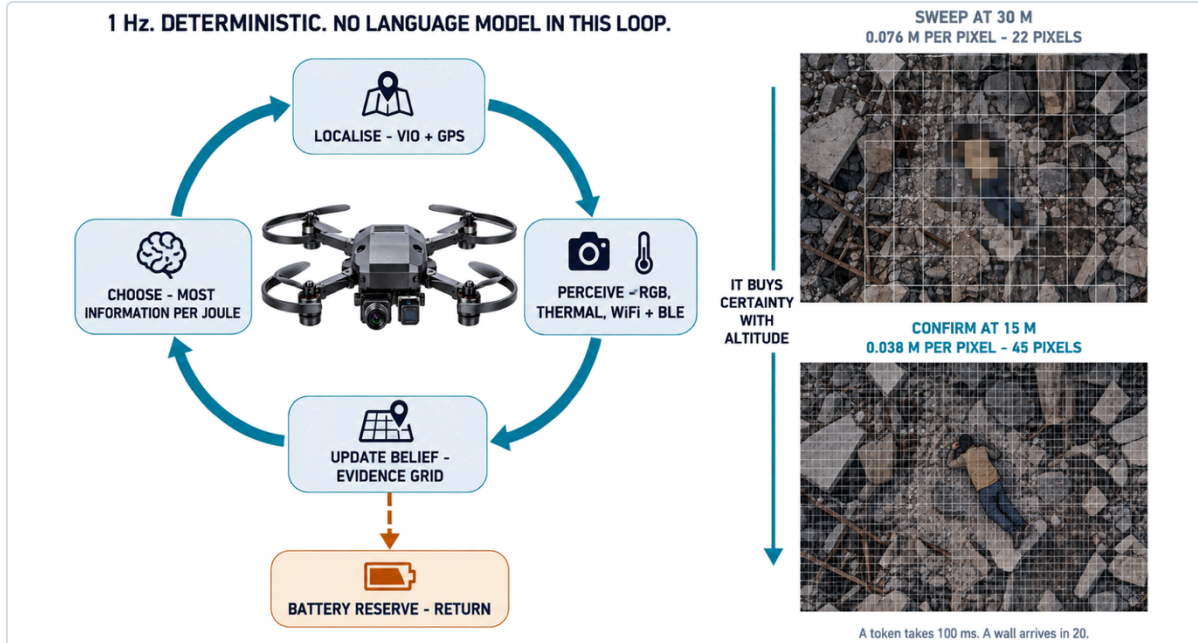
Detailed explanation — Scout = **Arduino UNO Q** (Qualcomm Dragonwing QRB2210 + real-time STM32U585). PX4 flies on the MCU at 1 kHz; YOLOv8n INT8, VIO and the decision tree run on Linux. RGB + thermal + its own Wi-Fi/BLE radio. The NDRF truck adds fused mapping and a language model — an **accelerator, never a dependency**.

How it addresses the problem — Wayanad 2024: 1,300 responders, 6 zones, **5+ days**, 206 never found. Six scouts sweep the same 15 km² in **5.8 hours** — **+64 survivors per 100 trapped**.

Innovation and uniqueness — **SACHET cell broadcast, inverted**. NDMA already reaches 1.43 bn handsets to say *evacuate*. One message saying *turn Bluetooth on* makes every phone a beacon — and the scout's own Qualcomm radio is already the receiver. **Zero added hardware, zero marginal cost**.

Detection is off-the-shelf. The decision layer is ours — and it is measured on Qualcomm silicon.

① HOW ONE AIRCRAFT DECIDES — 1 HZ, DETERMINISTIC



RUNS IN THE JUDGE'S BROWSER



Live demo

[hf.co/spaces/anshumanatrey/
kestrel-survivor-detection](https://hf.co/spaces/anshumanatrey/kestrel-survivor-detection)

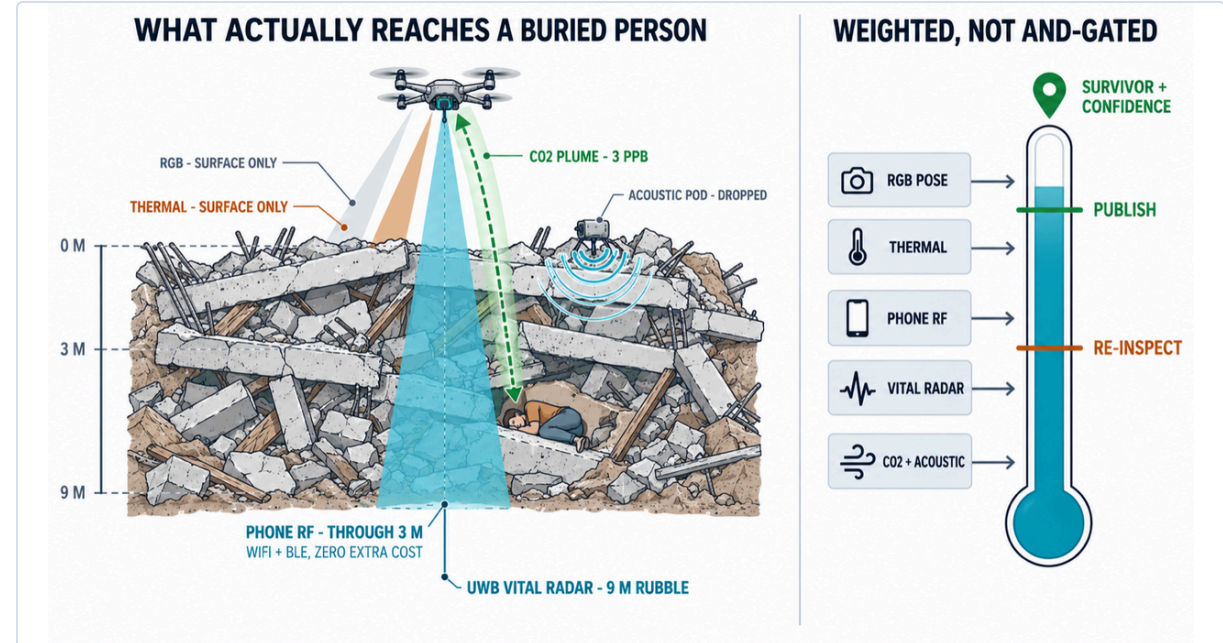
TECHNICAL APPROACH — REQUIRED POINTERS

Technologies — PX4 + ROS 2 · **Qualcomm Dragonwing** QRB2210 (scout) and QCS6490 / IQ-8275 (base) · YOLOv8n INT8 compiled through **Qualcomm AI Hub** → **QNN** · VINS-Fusion VIO for GPS-denied flight · Wi-Fi 5 + BT 5.1 mesh, LoRa backhaul, dropped breadcrumb relays.

Methodology — **four algorithms, not a wrapper**: (1) two-pass descent, SAHI-style, with min-window-cover crop planning, union-find cross-pass merging and weighted box fusion · (2) correlated Bayesian fusion solving $\Sigma w = 1$, which discounts sensors that fail together and reduces to Chair-Varshney when they do not · (3) prize-collecting **Held-Karp** route DP, exact, battery reserve inside the DP · (4) 0/1 knapsack for the LoRa frame. **9/9 self-tests against brute force.**

Measured, not estimated — YOLOv8n INT8 @640 on **Qualcomm AI Hub**, **real devices**: Arduino Ventuno Q (IQ-8275) **1.85 ms / 539 FPS**; Dragonwing RB3 Gen 2 (QCS6490) **11.21 ms / 89 FPS**. **247 of 247 layers on the Hexagon NPU, zero CPU fallback.** The sweep needs 0.22 Hz — the headroom runs detection, VIO and the radio scanner at once.

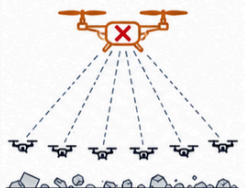
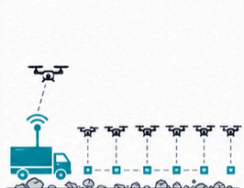
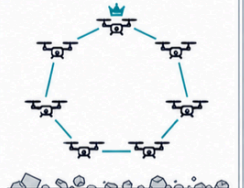
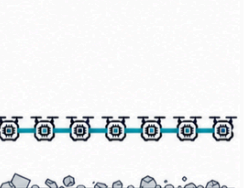
② WHAT ACTUALLY REACHES A BURIED PERSON



We built four architectures, scored them against our own criteria, and shipped the one that survives losing pieces.

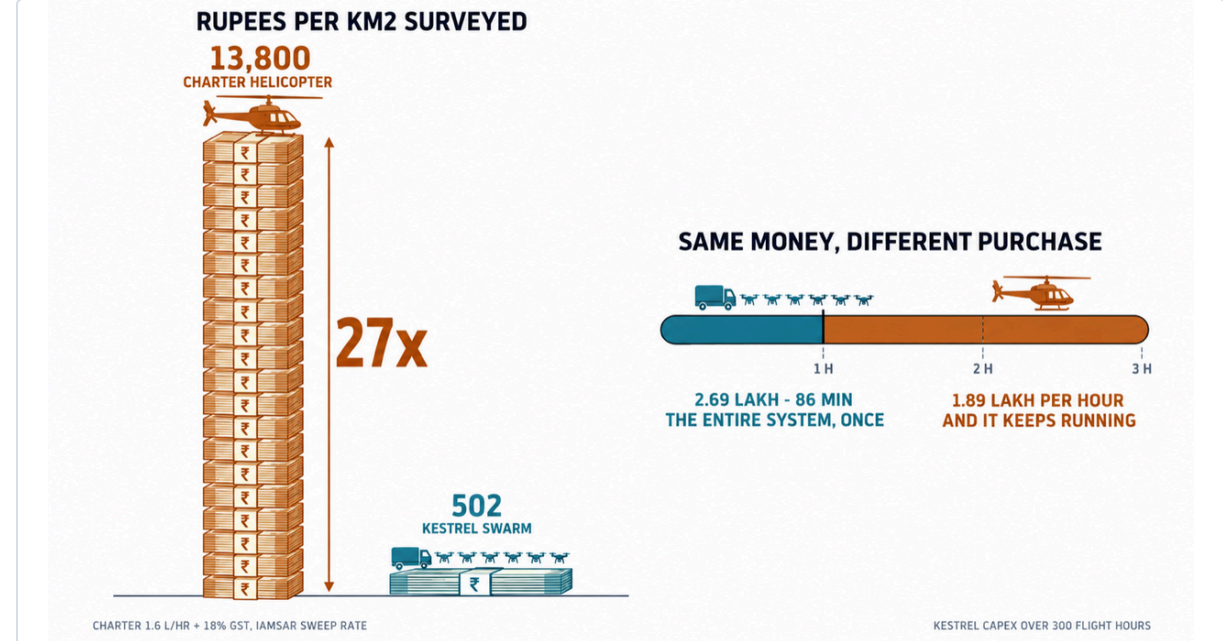
① THE ALTERNATIVES WE TESTED — AND WHY OURS WON

FOUR WAYS TO BUILD THIS. WE TESTED OURS.

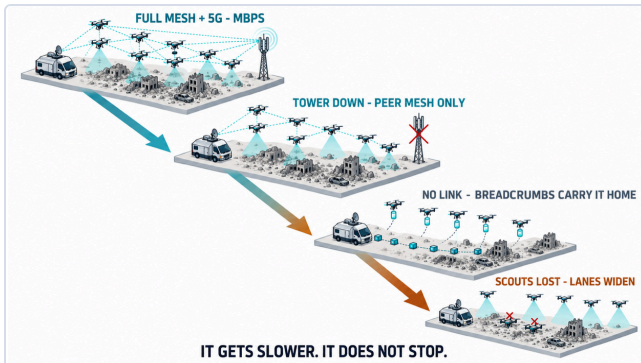
	A. FLYING MOTHERSHIP	B. TRUCK IS THE BASE	C. PEER SWARM	D. SWARM IS THE COMPUTER
				
NO SINGLE POINT OF FAILURE	✗	✓	✓	✓
COMPUTE FULLY USED	✗	✓	✗	✓
WORKS INSIDE BUILDINGS	✗	✓	✓	✓
EVERY NODE QUALCOMM	✓	✓	✓	✓
	OUR FIRST DESIGN			

Evidence: Zhejiang Science Robotics 2022; CERBERUS DARPA SubT; ACHORD; market-based replanning 2026

② WHAT IT COSTS AGAINST THE ALTERNATIVE



③ WHEN PIECES FAIL



FEASIBILITY AND VIABILITY — REQUIRED POINTERS

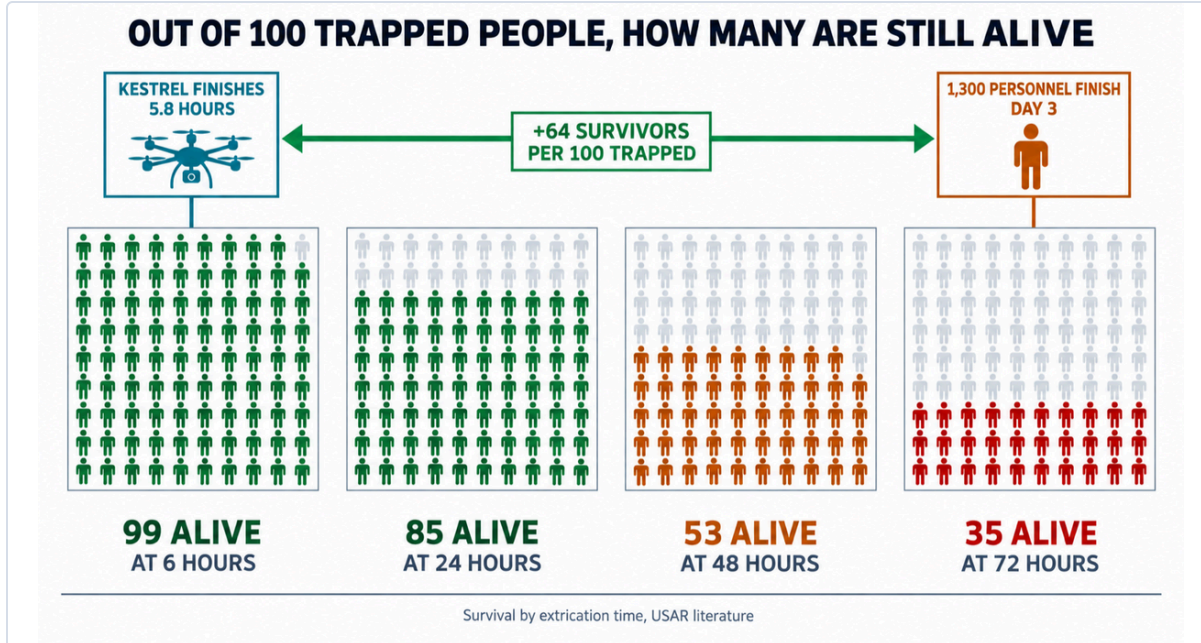
Feasibility — ₹2.68 lakh total, Indian-vendor sourced (Robu / Robocraze / Thundercomm). That is **86 minutes** of charter helicopter. Airframe, flight stack and radios are all commodity; the detector is already profiled on real Qualcomm hardware.

Potential challenges and risks — Thermal **inverts** on sun-heated rubble in daylight · VIO drifts ~0.5% of path, which is 21 m over a full sortie · FINDER-class radar **reported three breath signals at Wayanad where nothing was found** · a 500 mm airframe cannot enter a collapsed doorway.

Strategies for overcoming them — Independence weighting means **no single stream ever decides** — the radar that lied is one weighted vote · GPS-denied excursions are bounded to 1–3 min by breadcrumb anchors and loop closure at the truck, giving **1.2–3.6 m**, inside the re-inspect radius · interiors are reached by **dropped breadcrumb pods**, not by flying the sweep frame indoors · and the degradation ladder is designed so the system gets **slower, never offline**.

The 72-hour window is the entire problem. We move first contact from day three to hour six.

① OUT OF 100 TRAPPED PEOPLE, HOW MANY ARE STILL ALIVE



③ WHAT IT IS ALL FOR



IMPACT AND BENEFITS — REQUIRED POINTERS

Impact on the target audience — NDRF, SDRF and the Army search at roughly 0.1 km²/h per team. Kestrel sweeps **2.6 km²/h**. On the Wayanad footprint that is **5.8 hours instead of five days: 99 alive per 100** at six hours against **35 at seventy-two**.

Social — Responders stop walking unstable debris and live power lines to find out whether anyone is there. The aircraft takes that risk, and it takes it at night, in monsoon, without fatigue.

Economic — ₹502 per km² against ₹13,800 by charter helicopter — **27×**. Equipping all **738 districts** costs ≈ ₹19.86 Cr, which is **0.12%** of the national disaster preparedness line. It is already funded; it is a procurement decision, not a budget request.

Environmental — Battery-electric, no fuel burn, and the scout's brain is a ₹5,190 board rather than a ₹50,000 one.

② WHAT THE COMMANDER SEES — ON-DEVICE, NO NETWORK



Every number in this deck traces to a source. Every claim about our own silicon is a job ID you can open.

PEER-REVIEWED & FIELD EVIDENCE

- ▶ Team **CERBERUS**, winner, DARPA Subterranean Challenge 2021 — base-station compute + breadcrumbed radio nodes
- ▶ Zhejiang Univ., *Swarm of micro flying robots in the wild*, **Science Robotics 2022** — decentralised, no central aircraft
- ▶ Akyon et al., **SAHI**, arXiv **2202.06934** — slicing raises AP **+6.8%** on VisDrone with no retraining
- ▶ Solovyev et al., **Weighted Boxes Fusion**, arXiv 1910.13302
- ▶ **Chair & Varshney**, IEEE TAES 1986 — optimal LLR decision fusion; we generalise it to correlated streams
- ▶ *Sensors 18(3) 852* — CO₂ + thermal + microphone fusion for trapped-victim detection
- ▶ NASA JPL / DHS **FINDER** — 9 m rubble penetration; four men found alive, Nepal 2015
- ▶ **ACHORD** / CARA (JPL CoSTAR) — communication-aware coordination with droppable radios
- ▶ Held & Karp, *J. SIAM* 1962 — exact DP for the sequencing problem we solve per sortie
- ▶ UAV-VLRR arXiv 2503.02465 · **AVERY** arXiv 2511.18151 — VLM split computing for disaster response



Live demo — runs in your browser
Two-pass descent, correlated fusion, Held-Karp routing and the knapsack link budget, executing on *your* device. No server, no login.
huggingface.co/spaces/anshumanatrey/kestrel-survivor-detection

INDIAN OPERATIONAL & POLICY RECORD

- ▶ **Wayanad landslide**, 30 Jul 2024 — 1,300 personnel, 40 teams, 6 zones, 5+ days, 357 dead, **206 missing**, ~15 km²
- ▶ **C-DOT SACHET** / NDMA cell broadcast — 1.43 bn citizens, 36 states, 14.5 M tower cells
- ▶ **15th Finance Commission** 2021–26 — NDRF/SDRF preparedness allocation
- ▶ **DGCA** UAS Rules 2021 · Drone Rules amendment — micro/small category, RPC training
- ▶ **keralarescue.in**, Kerala 2018 — crowd-sourced rescue requests, IEEE Kerala + Kerala IT Mission
- ▶ **Nepal–Tibet glacial flood**, Aug–Sep 2026 · **Assam floods**, Jul–Aug 2026 — the live monsoon record
- ▶ **NDMA** / NDRF deployment doctrine — 40 teams across 6 zones is the Wayanad baseline we measure against
- ▶ **IAMSAR** sweep-width methodology — the ground-team rate our 0.1 km²/h figure derives from
- ▶ **ISRO Bhuvan** · Copernicus **Sentinel-1 SAR** — free pre-flight damage priors



Engineering record
Sourced data registry, BOM, every prompt, and the algorithm module with its brute-force self-tests.
github.com/AnshumanAtrey/sih2k26-the-drone-syndicate

QUALCOMM PLATFORM & OUR OWN MEASUREMENTS

- ▶ **Qualcomm AI Hub** — YOLOv8n INT8 @640, QNN DLC, `--quantize_io`, profiled on physical devices
- ▶ Arduino **Ventuno Q** (Dragonwing IQ-8275, Hexagon v75): **1.85 ms · 539 FPS · 247/247 NPU**
- ▶ Dragonwing **RB3 Gen 2** (QCS6490, Hexagon v68): **11.21 ms · 89 FPS · 247/247 NPU**
- ▶ Arduino **UNO Q** — QRB2210 + STM32U585, Wi-Fi 5 + BT 5.1, ₹5,190 (4 GB / 32 GB)
- ▶ **PX4 / ROS 2 / VINS-Fusion** — open flight and odometry stack
- ▶ *Third-party*: Foundries.io measured YOLOv5 Pico at **~17 FPS** on a physical UNO Q
- ▶ **SARD** search-and-rescue aerial dataset — 1,980 images, 6,525 person instances, fine-tune in progress
- ▶ **ONNX Runtime Web** — the demo executes in the judge's browser, no server and no upload
- ▶ *Honest limit*: **QRB2210 is not offered on AI Hub**, so the scout figure stays third-party

OUR OWN MEASUREMENTS — QUALCOMM AI HUB, PHYSICAL DEVICES, JOB IDS ON REQUEST

DEVICE	SILICON	PRECISION	LATENCY	THROUGHPUT	COMPUTE UNITS	PEAK MEMORY
Arduino Ventuno Q	Dragonwing IQ-8275 · Hexagon v75	INT8	1.85 ms	539.7 FPS	247 / 247 NPU	7.5 MB
Dragonwing RB3 Gen 2	QCS6490 · Hexagon v68	INT8	11.21 ms	89.2 FPS	247 / 247 NPU	9.1 MB
Arduino Ventuno Q	Dragonwing IQ-8275 · Hexagon v75	fp16	6.77 ms	147.8 FPS	247 / 247 NPU	16.5 MB
<i>Dragonwing RB3 Gen 2</i>	<i>QCS6490 · Hexagon v68</i>	<i>fp16</i>	<i>graph will not compose on Hexagon v68 — reported as a negative result, not omitted</i>			